~

Sulaiman Karrani, the Afghan sultan of Bihar and Bengal, died on the eve of Akbar's march into Gujarat. Ever since, various men had made grabs for his throne; none of them had gained unchallenged control of the east, and all of them had weakened – if not entirely undone – the careful balance of military strength and diplomatic subservience that had kept Sulaiman Karrani safe from the Mughals.

First, Sulaiman's eldest son and successor frittered away his inheritance by disparaging his nobility, and was murdered by his cousin. The cousin wasn't long on the throne either – he was soon dispatched by a nobleman called Lodi. Lodi had great influence over the Afghans of the east, and he decreed that Sulaiman's younger son, Daud, be crowned sultan. One eastern Afghan, however, did not want Lodi speaking for him: Gujar Khan, 'the sword of the country',[23] found himself a grandson of Sulaiman's and set up his own rule under the grandson's aegis. Daud, meanwhile, became increasingly suspicious of the man who'd made him king. A kingmaker, after all, can crown more than one head.

It was an ideal opportunity for the Mughals to exacerbate suspicions between the Afghans, divide their ambitions and swallow their land. There were three contending powers in Bengal and Bihar: Daud, Lodi and Gujar Khan; and Akbar's man in Jaunpur, Munim Khan, tried hard to sow dissension between them. Unfortunately, his intrigues had the opposite effect. In the winter of 1573, news arrived that Gujar Khan had mediated a peace between Lodi and Daud.

Had the Afghans remained united, Munim Khan might have had to return to Jaunpur with little achieved. But the star of the Afghans in the east was fading. The young Sultan Daud 'was a dissolute scamp', writes Nizamuddin, 'and knew nothing of the business of governing'. He was particularly ignorant of the principle of trust. Now, as Lodi began to negotiate with the Mughals to compel their retreat, Daud suspected that he was, in fact, brokering a deal to his own advantage. Thus, for no reason at all, Daud had his best adviser killed.

With Lodi perished Daud's chances; the Mughals were soon on his tail. The suspicious sultan fled to Patna and barricaded himself in the city, while Munim Khan began a long siege.